









## ROMANCE OF THE SEA.

### Relics of a Lost Tribe of Indians Were Found.

#### Exchange.

The schooner *Alexander*, Captain Scott, has lately returned to San Francisco from an otter-hunting trip along the Southern coast. The last point at which Captain Scott touched was San Nicholas Island, and he brought from there many curious relics of an ancient race of Indians.

San Nicholas Island is the most south-westerly of the little group off Santa Barbara, and it is many years since vessels have touched there. Captain Scott describes the place as one of the most barren spots on the earth, and yet up to half a century ago it was covered with vegetation and contained soil so rich that the rarest exotics flourished there. Now it is a sandy waste, the only sign of habitation being a flimsy looking hut of rough boards. Twenty or thirty sheep in a half-starved condition were the only signs of life visible and on the hilltops blenching in the sun were found the bones of hundreds of the ancient rulers of the island.

"We put in under the lee of the island," said Captain Scott to a reporter, "to get a safe harbor until the weather was propitious for otter-hunting. While there I determined to go ashore and see what kind of a place it was. We landed on the beach and the aspect was dreary enough. As far as the eye could reach over hill and lowland there was nothing to be seen but sand and rocks, and a little way off there were twenty or thirty sheep. They looked more

like wood-covered skeletons than anything else. One of the men ran after some of the animals and the latter hobbled about fifty yards and then dropped dead.

"The island is about ten miles long and five miles wide, and not a bit of soil is to be seen. There had been soil there once, but the sheep had dug up the grass by the roots and the wind blew the sand up all over the island. We went to the top of a little hill and there saw a most curious sight. Evidently this had been the graveyard of the former inhabitants, but no cross or monument marked the spot of burial.

"The wind had swept up the sand and left bare the bones of the dead. All around us were grinning skulls and whitened skeletons and the whistling wind, as it sougled through the little hills and valleys, lent a weird aspect to the scene. We gazed on the remains of what had been mighty specimens of manhood, for the size of the bones showed that the proportions of the dead men must have been immense. I am over six feet in height, and a number of thigh bones I measured extended far below my knee.

"I picked up this club," said the captain, exhibiting a heavy bar of sandstone. "It is evidently a war club, which was used hundreds of years ago, and you can tell by its hilt that it required a pretty strong man to wield it. Here is a mortar and pestle which I also picked up. There were a number of them scattered about the island. They were probably the property of the medicine men of the tribe.

"I have heard that the name of the tribe never could be learned and that but little is known about the Indians. The people

living in and about Santa Barbara in years gone by could not understand their language, and so never were able to find out much about them. Thirty years ago Captain Nideler went to San Nicholas in a schooner and took off what was left of the tribe. There were only fifteen there, one of the number being a woman. If the men had been warriors in times gone by, their martial spirit was then diminished, for they offered no resistance. When all hands were aboard and the anchor was about to be weighed the woman signified that she wanted to go ashore, and made the captain understand that her papoose had been left behind. She was rowed ashore, and as soon as her feet touched the beach she sped away like a deer. She was a woman fully six feet in height, comely and well formed, and built in proportion. After an unavailing search for several hours the men returned to the vessel.

"The woman remained on the island for ten years after that, although several hunting parties went after her at different times from Santa Barbara. She lived in a cave, subsisting on the mussels, and abalones which she gathered from the rocks. Finally she was caught, her pursuers

approach which she gathered from the rocks. Finally she was caught, her pursuers having got on her trail and followed her to her cavern home. She was taken to Santa Barbara, but civilization was too much for her and she died in a few months. She refused to sleep in a bed, preferring the floor and she used to play about the place like a child."

The war-club which Captain Scott brought up with him is twenty-four inches in length, nine inches in diameter at one end and five inches at the handle. The mortar is thirteen inches in diameter, and the pestle is about half the size of the club. The mortar has the appearance of having been hollowed out by the continual pounding of the pestle. Among the other relics of the tribe, Scott has a flint arrow-head about two inches in length and sharp as a needle at the point. He also has two flint balls with holes through them. He thinks that they are part of a three-ball catchall similar to that used by the Patagonians. The instrument of the latter consists of three balls, to which are attached strings. The latter meet and are fastened to a long leash or rope, and when thrown at a horse a bird or a man, if they strike the object the strings wind around and around holding the victim as tightly as a fish in the meshes of a net.